

Text and context in translation

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Abstract

While research on texts as units larger than sentences has a rich tradition in translation studies, the notion of context, its relation to text, and the role it plays in translation has received much less attention. In this paper, I make an attempt at rethinking the relationship between context and text for translation. I first review several conceptions of context and the relationship between text and context in a number of different disciplines. Secondly, I present a theory of translation which is to be understood as a theory of re-contextualization that explicates the relationship between context and text in its design and categorial scheme. Finally, I sketch a recent development in translation and multilingual text production, which may limit the scope of re-contextualization in translation.

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1. The notion of context in different traditions

The notion of context is central to a variety of disciplines concerned with language use, including translation studies. In the absence of a lively debate about context and its relation to text in translation studies, I will first give a brief outline of the major ideas about context – and by implication text and discourse – as they have been developed in different research traditions, before exploring their usefulness for translation.

1.1. *The philosophical tradition*

Philosophers who have concerned themselves with language have viewed context as either something contributing to the inherent deficiency of language as a tool for logical thought, or as something inherently worthwhile and constitutive of the *conditio humana*. It is the latter tradition

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which is of interest for translation. This tradition is often linked in modern philosophical thinking with the work of Wittgenstein (1958/1967:35) and his emphasis on language as a type of action. Wittgenstein recognized that the meaning of linguistic forms is their use, and that language is never used to simply describe the world around us, but functions inside actions, “language games” (*Sprachspielen*), which are embedded in a “form of life” (*Lebensform*). The idea of analysing language as action was further pursued in the tradition of the British Ordinary Language Philosophy, particularly by Austin (1962), who emphasized the importance of the context of a speech act for linguistic production and interpretation in the form of socio-cultural conventions. It is through these conventions that the force and type of speech acts is determined. Austin perceived that to perform a speech act depends on the relevant felicity conditions, which are in effect specifications of the context enveloping them. With his emphasis on conventions as shared norms, Austin – unlike later scholars concerned with speech act theory, most notably Searle – gives clear priority to social aspects of language rather than a speaker’s state of mind, intentions and feelings.

Another theory of context-dependency was developed by the German philosopher Gadamer (1986–1995). Gadamer also emphasizes the role of conventions, which are, in his opinion, taken for granted, hidden, continuous and beyond consciousness. The importance of conventions tacitly shared by text producers and receptors is reflected in Gadamer’s view of context, whereby detailed contextual–interpretive analysis of texts is necessary in order to achieve a “fusion of horizons”. Both writer and reader are united in their context-dependence. In opposition to the ideas of Popper (1989), who believes in the changeability of conventions and the necessity of critically reflecting on and revising them, Gadamer emphasizes the inherent limitations of both reflection and criticism, and he insists on the immutable character of context-dependence. Indeed, he argues that context-dependence and its attendant culture-specificity must involve an absence of self-awareness, thus treating context as a prison for the individual.

1.2. The psychological tradition

Particularly influential for further developments of ideas about context has been the notion of context formulated by Grice (1975) in his theory of implicature in language use. Grice assumed the operation of certain conversational maxims that guide the conduct of talk and stem from fundamental rational considerations of how to realize co-operative ends. These maxims express a general co-operative principle and specify how participants have to behave in order to converse in an optimally efficient, rational and co-operative way: participants should speak sincerely, clearly and relevantly and provide sufficient information for their interlocutors. In Grice’s view, speech is regarded as action, and it can be explained in terms of the beliefs and purposes of the actors. Grice’s theory is thus in essence a psychological or cognitive theory of rhetoric. This also holds for Sperber and Wilson’s (1986) relevance theory, in which the Gricean maxim of relevance is further developed, and in which context is clearly a psychological concept. Context is defined by Sperber and Wilson (1986:15) as “the set of premises used in interpreting it [an utterance]”; it is a cognitive construct and a “subset of the hearer’s assumptions about the world”. For Sperber and Wilson, then, context does not comprise external situational, cultural factors but is rather conceived as a “cognitive environment”, implying the mental availability of internalized environmental factors in an individual’s cognitive structure. Context is bound up with assumptions used by hearers to interpret utterances, and all interpretive efforts are made on the basis of the relevance of given assumptions, i.e., the likelihood that adequate contextual effects are achieved with a minimum of processing efforts. The principle of relevance is regarded as part

of general human psychology, and it is through this principle that humans are able to engage in interpreting utterances.

As opposed to such psychological approaches in which context is conceptualized as depending on an individual's internal psychological processes, socio-cognitive approaches to context consider language choices to be intimately connected with social-situational factors. Thus, [Forgas \(1985\)](#) stresses the important role social situations play for the way human beings use language. He considers verbal communication to be an essentially social act, and points to the fact that interaction between language and social context can be traced back to the early years of language acquisition (cf. [Bruner, 1981](#)). Both the meanings of utterances and the shared conceptions and definitions of the social context enveloping linguistic units are here regarded as the result of collective, supra-individual, cognitive activities.

But there is also a 'third way' in psychological theorizing about context. This encompasses both individual and social processes. Its propagators (e.g., [Clark, 1996](#)) focus both on individual cognitive processes and their social conditioning in concrete acts of language use. Language use is regarded as a form of joint action carried out collaboratively by speakers and hearers who form an ensemble. According to [Clark \(1996:29\)](#), "language use arises in joint activities", activities which are closely bound up with contexts and vary according to goals and other dimensions such as formal versus informal, egalitarian versus autocratic as well as other participant-related variables. Over and above taking account of these external dimensions, Clark also operates with the concept of 'common ground', taken over from [Stalnaker \(1978\)](#). This is a psychological notion which captures what speakers/hearers bring with them to a joint activity, i.e., their prior knowledge, beliefs, assumptions, etc., all of which accumulate in the course of the activity. Different types of common ground thus range from personal, communal, national to global, and comprise inferences about our common humanity as well as linguistic, dialectal, cultural and affective-emotive factors.

1.3. The pragmatics tradition

In the tradition of pragmatics, conceptualizations of context have played such an overwhelmingly important role that the very definition of pragmatics is often bound up with the notion of context. Thus, [Stalnaker \(1999:43\)](#) writes that "Syntax studies sentences, semantics studies propositions. Pragmatics is the study of linguistic acts and the contexts in which they are performed". And we might even say, with [Levinson \(1983:32\)](#), that pragmatics is "a theory of language understanding that takes context into account". The underlying assumption here is that in order to arrive at an adequate theory of the relation between linguistic expressions and what they express, one must consider the context in which these expressions are used. In pragmatics, attention is given to how the interaction of context and content can be represented, how the linguistic expressions used relate to context. The relationship between content and context is however never a one-way street: content expressed also influences context, i.e., linguistic actions influence the context in which they are performed. The effects of this dependency are omnipresent and decisive for the construction and recovery of meaning. But context also plays a role in the overall organization of language, affecting its syntactic, semantic, lexical and phonological structure to the point that, as [Ochs \(1979:5\)](#) puts it, "we could say that a universal design feature of language is that it is context-sensitive".

A pragmatic framework would then need to include a general representation of contextual features that determine the values of linguistic expressions, with context being represented by a body of information presumed to be available to the participants in the speech situation. Given

the need to specify context as features of this situation, a distinction must be made between actual situations of utterance in all their manifold variety and the selection of only those features that are linguistically and socio-culturally relevant for both the speaker producing a particular utterance and the hearer who interprets it.

It is exactly this distinction that Leech (1983) refers to when he distinguishes between general pragmatics on the one hand and sociopragmatics or pragmalinguistics on the other, and pleads for the usefulness of a narrow view of context as background knowledge shared by addresser and addressee and contributing to the addressees' interpretation of what the addresser means by his or her utterance. Context in this more specific sense would then cover "the social and psychological world in which the language user operates at any given time" (Ochs, 1979:1). This includes participants' knowledge, beliefs and assumptions about temporal, spatial and social settings, previous, ongoing and future (verbal and non-verbal) actions, knowledge of the role and status of speaker and hearer, of spatial and temporal location, of formality level, medium, appropriate subject matter, province or domain determining the register of language (cf. Lyons, 1977:574 and Halliday, 1994, on whom more is given below). As has been pointed out in particular by Gumperz (1992), context-indexical linguistic features, which he calls "contextualization cues", invoke the relevant contextual assumptions. Among the linguistic features to be accounted for in an adequate notion of context, linguistic context or 'co-text' must also be evoked, i.e., the place of the current utterance in the sequence of utterances in the unfolding text/discourse must also be considered.

1.4. Sociolinguistic, anthropological and conversation analytical traditions

For scholars working in the fields of interactional sociolinguistics, anthropology or conversation analysis, the notion of context is of inherent, discipline-constitutive interest for a number of reasons: firstly, the features of face-to-face interaction are both a primary exemplar of context and an elementary example of human social organization; secondly, the way talk in interaction is designed for, and shaped by, features of the social situation sheds light on the organization of language itself; and finally, interactants have to accomplish understanding aided by context (Duranti and Goodwin, 1992:22). Accomplishing shared agreement about the events jointly experienced by members of a particular society is of course central to what anthropologists have traditionally been concerned with in their analyses of culture, and it is also central to research into the social organization of cognition and intersubjectivity underlying talk, which has traditionally been a mainstay in all ethnographically oriented research (e.g., Cicourel, 1992).

Another example of the assumption of the decisive influence of context on utterance content in anthropology is the notion of *framing*, first introduced by Bateson (1972) and significantly further developed by Goffman (1974). In framing their verbal behaviour, speakers and addressees can transform conventionalized expectations to fit a specific, local context and invoke genre changes.

In conversation analysis, the focus is on the analysis of talk-in-interaction and on the significance of sequential utterances as both context-creating and context-determined. According to Heritage (1984), talk is in fact 'doubly contextual' since utterances are realized and organized sequentially and linearly in time, such that any subsequent utterance relies on the existing context for its production and interpretation, but also constitutes an event in its own right which itself engenders a new context for the following utterances. Over and above this local organization of interaction in context, there have been recent suggestions that interaction is based on the possibility of 'projection', with the grammar of a language providing speakers and addressees

with more extensive shared paths (Auer, 2005). In other words, grammar and interaction share the common feature of ‘projectability’. This idea is consistent with seeing context as being in a dynamic relationship with linguistic phenomena, i.e., context and talk stand in a reflexive relationship, with talk and the interpretation it instigates shaping context as much as context shapes talk.

1.5. Functional–pragmatic and systemic–functional traditions

The mutual influence between talk and context is also emphasized by German functional–pragmatists of the Wunderlich school (e.g., Ehlich and Rehbein, 1979; Rehbein and Kameyama, 2004). Scholars in this paradigm plead for a concept of context that integrates cognitive knowledge and social–institutional factors, which are seen to influence one another. They criticize, however, both the conversation analytic view of context as something that is construed on a local, ad hoc and linearly temporal basis, and the interpretative sociolinguists’ view that the contextual environment (including language itself) is projected solely via indexicality onto individual actants. Functional pragmatic scholars point out (rightly to my mind) that such a view of context really only applies to oral language, not to written language. I would support this criticism, and also extend it to the conceptions of context propagated in all the traditions reviewed above, where the critically different constraints holding in written language are not consistently explicated because of these traditions’ bias towards spoken language.

In the functional–pragmatic approach, the speech situation is defined as an action situation in which linguistic forms such as personal pronouns, sentence types and modality assume new, contextually determined values. The approach makes an explicit distinction between online emergent talk and pre-fixed written texts. Context is here replaced by the notion of ‘constellation’, a situation of joint actions in which the communicative needs and goals of actants – both as actants co-present in an oral speech situation and as actants separated in space and time in the “stretched-out speech situation” characterizing written language – are accounted for, and communicative deep structures are represented. Constellations play an important role in the pragmatic analysis of the mood of an utterance (question, command, assertion), which is recognized as being both ontologically and phylogenetically of primary importance. Such a view is very similar to Halliday’s (1994:58) systemic–functional theory, which I describe in more detail below and where, in a comparable way, fundamental speech roles (such as giving or requesting information or goods and services) and their functional basis are regarded as primary. In both functional–pragmatic and systemic–functional theory, the preference for using a broad textual functional explanation for linguistic phenomena, combined with a detailed description of linguistic expressions in both their oral and written contexts, makes these approaches – unlike all others reviewed above – useful and appropriate for the interpretation, analysis and production of text, which is what we are concerned with in translation: translation is an operation on (pre-existing) written text as opposed to talk as oral, linearly and sequentially unfolding, negotiable discourse.

To sum up the discussion so far, context is a highly complex notion, conceptualized in a variety of ways in different disciplines, some of which I have briefly characterized above. Context can be regarded as encompassing external (situational and cultural) factors and/or internal, cognitive factors, all of which can influence one another in acts of speaking and listening. In many approaches, context – and the relationship between context and language – is regarded as dynamic rather than static. Context is taken to be more than a set of pre-fixed discrete variables that impact on language, and context and language are considered to be in a mutually reflexive relationship, such that language shapes context as much as context shapes language.

However, such a view of context is not useful for translation. True, translation is an act of performance, of language use, and it may well be conceptualized as a process of re-contextualization, because in translating, stretches of language are not only given a new shape in a new language, but are also taken out of their earlier, original context and placed in a new context, with different values assigned to communicative conventions, genres, readers' expectation norms, etc. What is of crucial importance in translation is the fact that a 'finished', and in this sense 'static' stretch of written language as text is presented to the translator in its entirety from the start of his or her translating activity. The task of translating as re-contextualization then consists of enacting a discourse out of the written text, i.e., the translator must create a 'living', but essentially not dynamic, cognito-social entity replete with contextual connections (cf. Widdowson, 2004:8ff). The new context in the target language is not conceived as dynamic or negotiated because of the power relationship implied by the connection between text and translator. Its 'static' quality arises in the very space opened up by the separation in time and space of writer and reader, and by means of the ability of the translator herself to define what the context is. This is very different from the type of context invoked in conversational interaction, where spoken text is a direct reflection of the discourse enacted between two or more co-present interactants and a discourse dynamically unfolds, sequentially develops, and explicitly and overtly involves speaker and hearer turns-at-talk. For translation, the availability of a written text at once in its entirety (as opposed to the bit-by-bit unfolding of negotiable text and discourse) is indeed constitutive. From this it follows that context cannot be regarded in translation as dynamic. True to the nature of written language, the realization of a discourse out of a text presented in writing only involves imaginary, hidden interaction between writer and reader in the minds of translators, where the natural unity of speaker and listener in oral interaction is replaced by the real-world separateness in space and time of writer and reader. The only way in which the translator can overcome this separateness and create a new unity is to transcend the givenness of the text with its immutable arrangement of linguistic elements by activating its contextual connections, by linking the text to both its old and its new context, which a translator must imagine and unite in his or her mind. This view of translation as an act of re-contextualization will be further developed in the following section, where a theory of re-contextualization is presented.

2. Text and context in translation: translation as re-contextualization

For a theory of translation as re-contextualization to achieve descriptive and explanatory adequacy, views of context as ongoing and changeable in emergent stretches of discourse must – as argued above – be discarded, because the nature of written texts with its in-built temporal and spatial constraints necessitates a different view of context. This view consists of treating context as a means of converting "inert text" (Widdowson, 2004:8) into discourse in an *ex post facto*, solitarily cognitive pragmatic process of meaning negotiation. A workable re-contextualization theory of translation would then include a view of text as a stretch of contextually embedded language. As Malinowski (1935) has argued, the meaning of a linguistic unit cannot be captured unless one takes account of the interrelationship between linguistic units and the context of the situation. On this view, translation becomes "rather the placing of linguistic symbols against the cultural background of a society than the rendering of words by their equivalents in another language" (Malinowski, 1935:18). The notion of context of the situation – developed in systemic-functional theory by Halliday (1994) and his collaborators (most recently Halliday and Matthiessen, 2004) – is of fundamental importance for a theory of translation as re-contextualization, and indeed for the

theoretical possibility of translation. We can assume that whenever communication is possible between speakers of the same language, it is also possible between speakers of different languages, and for the same fundamental reasons, i.e., because speakers relate linguistic units to the enveloping context of situation, analyse common situations and identify those situations whose distinctive and unfamiliar features are peculiar, such that they can be known, interpreted and re-contextualized in the minds of translators and their addressees. As mentioned above, such an *ex post facto*, re-creative act on the part of the translator is critically different from the type of observable on-line control participants in talk-in-interaction can have over the path of the emergent discourse.

For a theory of translation as re-contextualization to be valid, it has to fulfil at least the following three criteria regarding the relationship between text and context: (1) it has to explicitly account for the fact that source and translation texts relate to different contexts; (2) it has to be able to capture, describe and explain changes necessitated in the act of re-contextualization with a suitable metalanguage; and (3) it has to explicitly relate features of the source text and features of the translation to one another and to their different contexts. In the following section, I present and discuss an example of such a re-contextualization theory of translation and assess its validity in the light of the above criteria.

2.1. A systemic–functional theory of translation as re-contextualization

The theory of translation as re-contextualization to be presented in what follows is suggested in a functional model of translation first developed in House (1977, 1981) and revised in House (1997). The model is based on Hallidayan systemic–functional theory and is also eclectically informed by discourse analytic and functional-pragmatic approaches. Before describing the model, a few remarks on some basic assumptions about translation underlying this theory are necessary.

One of the fundamental concepts in translation theory is that of translation equivalence. Equivalence also underpins our everyday understanding of translation: linguistically naïve persons tend to think of translation as a text which is a sort of ‘reproduction’ of a text originally produced in another language, where this reproduction is somehow of comparable value. A translation can therefore be understood as a text which is doubly contextually bound: on the one hand to its contextually embedded source text and on the other to the (potential) recipient’s communicative-contextual conditions. This double-linkage is the basis of the so-called equivalence relation and at the same time the conceptual heart of translation. To quote John Catford (1965:21), “The central problem of translation-practice is that of finding TL (target language) equivalents. A central task of translation theory is therefore that of defining the nature and conditions of translation equivalence”.

Equivalence, like context, is obviously a relative concept; it has nothing to do with identity. Absolute equivalence would in fact be a *contradictio in adiecto*. Equivalence is a relative concept in several respects; it is determined by the socio-historical conditions in which the translation act is embedded, and by the range of often irreconcilable linguistic and contextual factors at play, among them at least the following: source and target languages with their specific structural constraints; the extra-linguistic world and the way this world is perceived by the two language communities; the linguistic conventions of the translator and of the target language and culture; structural, connotative and aesthetic features of the original; the translator’s comprehension and interpretation of the original and her creativity; the translator’s explicit and/or implicit theory of translation; translation traditions in the target culture; interpretation of the original by its author; audience design as well as generic norms, and possibly many more. In setting up such a variety of

“equivalence frameworks” (Koller, 1995), the concept of equivalence can be specified or operationalized. We can easily see that these frameworks are in fact specifications of context that are very much in line with Ochs’ and Lyons’ suggestions described above.

Given these different types of equivalence in translation, and given the nature of translation as a decision process (Levy, 1967), the translator is always forced to make choices, i.e., to set up a hierarchy of demands on equivalence which he or she wants to follow. Since appropriate use of language in communicative performance is what matters most in translation, it is functional, pragmatic equivalence which is of particular relevance for translation. And it is this type of equivalence which underpins the systemic–functional model to be described here, a model that attempts to explicate the way meaning can be re-constituted across two different contexts. Three aspects of that meaning are particularly important for translation: a semantic, a pragmatic and a textual aspect. Translation can then be defined as the replacement of a text in a source language by a semantically and pragmatically equivalent text in a target language. An adequate translation is thus a pragmatically and semantically equivalent one. As a first requirement for this equivalence, it is posited that *a translation text have a function equivalent to that of its original*. This requirement is later differentiated on the basis of an empirically derived distinction between different types of translation.

The use of the concept of function presupposes that there are elements in a text which, given appropriate tools, can reveal that text’s function. Function here is not to be equated with ‘functions of language’ as they have been suggested by many philosophers and linguists such as Bühler, Jakobson, Ogden and Richards and Popper. Different language functions clearly always co-exist in any text, and a simple equation of language function and textual function/textual type (a procedure adopted by Reiß, 1971 and many translation scholars following her) is overly simplistic. Rather, a text’s function is to be defined pragmatically as the application or use of the text in a particular context. And, as we have seen above, the context in which the text unfolds is encapsulated in the text since there is a systematic relationship between the social environment on the one hand and the functional organization of language-in-text on the other. This means that the text must first be referred to the particular situation enveloping it, and for this a way must be found to break down the broad notion of context into manageable parts or ‘situational dimensions’. In systemic–functional linguistics, many different systems have been suggested which specify such dimensions as abstract components of the context, for instance by Crystal and Davy (1969) in their very detailed scheme, which was, in fact, adapted as the basis for the original eclectic re-contextualization theory of translation in House (1977, 1981). I restrict myself here to describing the revised version of this theory (House, 1997), where the classic Hallidayan contextual concepts of *Field*, *Mode* and *Tenor* are taken over and modified for the purpose of constructing a re-contextualization theory of translation.

Briefly, the dimension of *Field* captures social activity and topic, with differentiations of degrees of generality, specificity or granularity in lexical items. *Tenor* refers to the nature of the participants and the relationship between them in terms of social power, distance and degree of emotional charge. Included here are the text producer’s temporal, geographical and social provenances as well as her intellectual, emotional or affective stance (her personal viewpoint) vis-à-vis the content she has expressed and the communicative task in which she was engaged. Further, *Tenor* captures social attitude, i.e., different styles such as formal, consultative or informal. *Mode* refers to both the channel – spoken or written (which can be simple or complex) – and the degree to which potential or real participation is allowed for between writer and reader. Participation can be simple, as in a monologue with no addressee participation built into the text, or complex. In taking account of linguistically documentable differences between the spoken and

written medium, reference is also made to the empirically established, corpus-based oral-literate dimensions hypothesized by Biber (1988), who suggests several dimensions along which linguistic choices may reflect medium, namely, involved versus informational text production; explicit versus situation-dependent reference; abstract versus non-abstract presentation of information.

The type of linguistic-textual analysis in which linguistic features discovered in the original are correlated with the contextual register-categories *Field*, *Tenor* and *Mode* in an attempt to enact a ‘living discourse’ does not, however, directly lead to a statement of the individual textual function. For this, the category *Genre* is taken into account. *Genre* is incorporated into the analytic scheme in between, as it were, the register categories and the textual function. Considerations of genre enable the translator to refer any single textual exemplar to the class of texts with which it shares a common purpose. Although the category *Register* refers to the relationship between text and context, register descriptions are basically limited to capturing individual features on the linguistic surface. In order to characterize deeper textual structures and patterns, a different conceptualization, namely *Genre*, is needed as a category superordinate to register. While *Register* captures the connection between texts and their micro-context, *Genre* connects texts with the macro-context of the linguistic and cultural community in which they are embedded. *Register* and *Genre* are both semiotic systems realized by language, such that the relationship between *Genre*, *Register* and *Language/Text* is one between semiotic planes which relate to one another in a Hjelmslevian “content-expression” type. In other words, *Genre* is the content plane of *Register*, and *Register* is the expression plane of *Genre*. *Register* in turn is the content plane of *Language*, with *Language* being the expression plane of *Register* (Martin, 1993). The resultant scheme for textual analysis, comparison and assessment is outlined in Fig. 1.

Taken together, the analysis provided in this re-contextualization theory of translation yields a text–context profile which realizes a discourse and characterizes the individual textual function. Whether and how this function can be maintained, however, depends critically on the type of translation sought for the original. In the following section, two fundamentally different types of translation are distinguished and discussed in some detail.

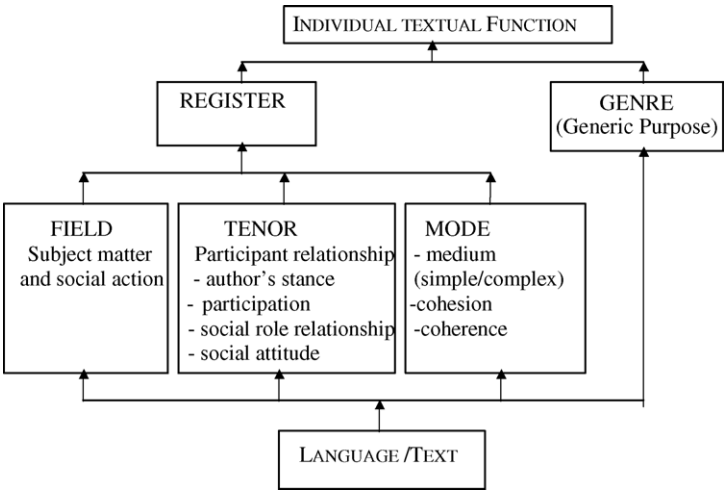


Fig. 1. Scheme for analysing and comparing original and translation texts.

2.2. Two types of translation

The two types of translation – which I have called *overt* and *covert* translation – are the result of different strategies of re-contextualization. They can be related to Friedrich Schleiermacher's (1813) well-known distinction between “*verfremdende und einbürgernde Übersetzungen*” (glossed as ‘alienating’ and ‘integrating’ translations), which has had many imitators using outwardly different but essentially compatible terms. What sets the overt–covert distinction apart from other similar distinctions is the fact that it is integrated into a coherent theory of translation, within which the origin and function of these terms are consistently explicated and contextually motivated.

In an *overt translation*, the receptors of the translation are quite ‘overtly’ not being directly addressed; an overt translation is thus one which is overtly a translation, not as it were a ‘second original’. Originals that call for an overt translation tend to have an established worth in the source language community: they are either tied to a specific occasion in which a precisely specified source language audience is/was being addressed or they are timeless originals, for example works of art and aesthetic creations with a distinct historical meaning, as well as political speeches and religious sermons. A *covert translation*, on the other hand, is a translation which enjoys the status of an original source text in the target culture. The translation is covert because it is not marked pragmatically as a translation of a source text but may, conceivably, have been created in its own right. A covert translation is thus a translation whose source text is not specifically addressed to a particular source culture audience, i.e., it is not firmly tied to the source culture context. Examples include tourist information booklets and computer manuals. A source text and its covert translation are pragmatically of equal concern for source and target language addressees; both are, as it were, equally directly addressed. A source text and its covert translation have equivalent purposes, they are based on contemporary equivalent needs of a comparable audience in the context of the source and target language communities. In the case of covert translation, it is thus both possible and desirable to keep the function of the source text equivalent in the translation. This can be done by inserting a ‘cultural filter’ (described below) between original and translation with which to account for cultural differences between the two linguistic communities.

Translation involves the movement of text across time and space, and whenever texts move, they also shift frames and discourse worlds. As discussed above, *Frame* is a socio-psychological concept—often seen as the psychological correlate to the more socially conceived notion of context. A frame delimits a class of meaningful actions virulent in text producers’ and receptors’ minds; it often operates unconsciously as a type of explanatory principle, i.e., a frame gives receptors instructions in their interpretation of the message included in the frame. Similarly, the notion of a ‘discourse world’ is interpreted as referring to a superordinate structure for interpreting meaning in a certain way, as is for instance explicated in Edmondson's (1981) discourse model, where a locutionary act acquires an illocutionary value by reference to an operant discourse world. Applying the concepts of frame, context and discourse world to overt and covert translation, we can state the following. In *overt* translation, the translation text is embedded in a new speech event, which also gives it a new frame and context. An overt translation is a case of language mention (as opposed to language use in covert translation); it is similar to a quotation. Relating the concept of overt translation to the four-tiered analytical model (*Function–Genre–Register–Language/Text*), we can state that an original and its overt translation are to be equivalent at the level of *Language/Text* and *Register* as well as *Genre*. At the level of the individual textual function, functional equivalence, while still possible, is of an eminently

different nature: it can be described as enabling access to the function the original has in its discourse world, frame and context. As this access is to be realized in a different language and takes place in the target linguistic and cultural community, a switch in discourse world frame and context becomes necessary, i.e., the translation is differently framed and contextualized, it operates in its own frame, context and discourse world, and can thus reach at best *second-level functional equivalence*. Since this type of equivalence is, however, achieved through equivalence at the levels of *Language/Text*, *Register* and *Genre*, the original's frame and discourse world are co-activated in the minds of the translator and her potential readers in the new context, such that they can eavesdrop, as it were, i.e., be enabled to appreciate the original textual function, albeit at a distance. In overt translation, the work of the translator is therefore important and visible. Since it is the translator's task to give target culture members access to the original text and its cultural impact on source culture members, the translator puts target culture members in a position to observe and/or judge this text 'from outside'.

In *covert translation*, on the other hand, the translator attempts to re-create as far as possible an equivalent speech event. Consequently, a covert translation attempts to reproduce the function which the original has within its frame and discourse world. A covert translation therefore operates in the context, frame and discourse world provided by the target culture, with no attempt being made to co-activate the discourse world in which the original unfolded. Covert translation is at the same time psycholinguistically less complex and more deceptive than overt translation. It is the translator's express task to 'betray' the original and as it were hide behind its transformation. The translator is here clearly less visible, if not totally absent from view. Since true functional equivalence is aimed at, the original may be legitimately manipulated at the levels of *Language/Text* and *Register* via the use of a cultural filter. The result may be a very real distance from the original. While the original and its covert translation need not be equivalent at the levels of *Language/Text* and *Register*, equivalence can be achieved at the levels of *Genre* and the *Individual Textual Function*.

The assumption that a particular text *requires* either a covert or an overt translation does not hold in any simple way. Thus, any text may, for a specific purpose, be translated overtly, i.e., it may be viewed as a document which has an independent value, for example, when its author has become, in the course of time, a distinguished figure. Furthermore, there may well be source texts for which the choice of overt–covert translation is a subjective one. For instance, fairy tales may be viewed as products of a particular culture, which would predispose the translator to opt for an overt translation, or as non-culture specific texts, anonymously produced, with the general function of entertaining and educating the young, which would suggest a covert translation. Or consider the case of the Bible, which may be treated as either a collection of historical literary documents, in which case an overt translation would seem to be called for, or as a collection of human truths directly relevant to all human beings, in which case a covert translation might seem appropriate. Moreover, the specific purpose for which a translation is produced, i.e., the particular brief given to the translator, will of course determine whether a translation or an overt version¹ should be aimed at. In other words, just as the decision as to whether an overt or covert translation is appropriate for a particular source text may depend on contextual factors such as the changeable status of the text author, so clearly the initial choice between translating and producing a version cannot be made on the basis of features of the text alone but may depend on the purpose for which the translation or version is required in a new context.

¹ On the distinction between translation and version, see section 2.4 below.

In the re-contextualization process involved in translation, it is thus essential that the fundamental differences between overt and covert translation be taken into account. In overt translation, the difficulty is generally reduced in that considerations of cultural filtering can be omitted. Overt translations are in this sense more straightforward. The major difficulty in translating overtly lies in finding linguistic–contextual equivalents, particularly along the dimension of *Tenor*. Here we deal with overt manifestations of contextual phenomena, which need to be considered only because they happen to be linguistically manifest in the original. For instance, making a decision as to whether a certain regional or social variety depicted in the original text is adequately rendered in overt translation is ultimately not objectively possible: the degree of correspondence in terms of social prestige and status cannot be measured in the absence of comprehensive contrastive ethnographic studies—if, indeed, such studies are ever likely to exist. However, as opposed to the difficulty of accounting for differences in cultural presuppositions and contextually based preferences between text production in source and target contexts in covert translation processes, re-contextualization in overt translation is still more easily fashioned and legitimized. In the production of a covert translation, translators have to consider in greater depth and detail the new context into which they have to ‘insert’ their translation; in other words, they have to apply a cultural filter. I discuss the concept, function and implications of such a filter in the next section.

2.3. Concept, function and implications of a cultural filter: evidence from contrastive analyses

A cultural filter is a means of capturing cognitive and socio-cultural differences in expectation norms and discourse conventions between source and target linguistic–cultural communities. The application of such a filter should ideally not be based exclusively on the translator’s subjective, accidental intuitions but be – as far as possible – in line with relevant empirical cross-cultural research. Before discussing an example of such cross-cultural research, I will first clarify what is to be understood by culture and what is meant by linguistic–cultural relativity—important concepts in any theory of translation as re-contextualization.

Like context, the concept of culture has been the concern of many different disciplines and the definitions offered vary according to the particular frame of reference invoked. Two basic views of culture can however be isolated: the humanistic and the anthropological. The humanistic concept of culture captures the ‘cultural heritage’ as a model of refinement, an exclusive collection of a community’s masterpieces in literature, fine arts, music and so on. The anthropological concept of culture refers to the overall way of life of a community or society, i.e., all those traditional, explicit and implicit designs for living which act as potential guides for the behaviour of members of the culture. Culture in the anthropological sense of a group’s dominant and learned sets of habits, as the totality of its non-biological inheritance, involves presuppositions, preferences and values – all of which are, of course, neither easily accessible nor verifiable and are in a constant process of change. For translation, the broad anthropological sense of culture seems to be the most fruitful. It is traditionally defined as

whatever it is one has to know or believe in order to operate in a manner acceptable to its [a society’s] members, and do so in any role that they accept for any one of themselves Culture is not a material phenomenon; it does not consist of things, people, behaviour, or emotions. It is rather an organization of these things. It is the forms of things that people have in mind, their model of perceiving, relating, and otherwise interpreting them.

(Goodenough, 1964:36)

Here we have the two salient and recurrent aspects of the (traditional) anthropological view of culture: the cognitive aspect, guiding and monitoring human actions, and the social aspect, emphasizing traditional features shared by members of a group, and these two aspects also reflect and encapsulate many facets of the concept of context reviewed above. In referring to such a view of culture, I am of course aware of the fact that it is somewhat ‘dated’, i.e., it stems from a time when ‘culture’ was construed as a basically homogeneous, consensual, non-contested domain. I am further aware of the fact that more modern, contemporary conceptions of culture (cf. Clifford, 1992; Ingold, 1994; Sarangi, 1995; Holliday, 1999, and many others) emphasize the negotiated, contested and, indeed, political nature of cultural processes, thus criticizing the legitimacy of the very notion of ‘a culture’ as essentialist and reified in a fixed set of relationships, and preferring instead a concept of culture as a set of processes about ideas, values, relationships, etc. which admit questions of power, actors’ interests, subject positioning and ideological conditioning. Obviously there is no such thing as a stable social group uninfluenced by external and internal pressures and idiosyncrasies, and it is clearly wrong to assume a unified culture out of which all differences between people are idealized and cancelled out. However, I would insist that such a dynamic conception of culture is in the last analysis not useful for translation, because it cannot be operationalized, just as a view of context as unfolding, negotiable and dynamic is inadequate for a theory of translation. In translating a text one cannot but refer to a concrete point in time and space, and it is here that the idea of negotiation must be given up if one wants to get on with the business of comprehending, interpreting, analysing and reproducing, i.e., translating. In other words, for methodological reasons, one cannot but adopt a static, necessarily reified viewpoint of text and culture. Such a viewpoint should not be disqualified as ignoring or dismissing the real complexity and in-flux-nature of culture; rather, it should be seen as taking account of existing descriptions of cultures as interpretive devices for understanding emergent behaviour in certain groups. It further acknowledges the way members of a particular group reportedly perceive members of another group as different in terms of talking and behaving in particular situated discourse events.

A socio-cognitive approach to explaining culture which can be seen as a contribution to resolving the issue of generalization versus diversification, relativization and individualization of cultures is offered by Sperber (1996). He views culture in terms of different types of representations (of ideas, behaviours, attitudes, values, norms, etc.). A multitude of individual mental representations exist within each group. A subset of these which can be overtly expressed in language and artefacts turn into public representations, which are communicated to others in the social group. This communication gives rise to similar mental representations in others, which may again be communicated involving the creation of mental representations, and so on. If a subset of these representations is communicated frequently enough within a social group, these representations will become firmly entrenched and turn into cultural representations. Members of a particular culture are constantly being influenced by their society’s (and/or some of the society’s subgroup’s) public and cultural representations and this influence is exerted most prominently through language and discourse as used by members of the culture in communication with other members of the same group, and it is primarily through communicative interchanges with other members of their culture that they construct their view of the world and their personality. Given such a socio-cognitive approach to culture, there may be some justification in trying to describe culturally conditioned discourse phenomena from the dialectically linked etic (culturally distant) and emic (culturally intrinsic) perspectives (cf. also Hymes, 1996 for further argumentation).

Within the literature on what might be termed ‘linguistic cultural relativity’, languages are seen as structured in divergent ways because they embody different conventions, experiences and values. Such a notion of relativity is much more relevant for translation (for a detailed discussion see House, 2000). While a glance at the rich anecdotal literature on translation describing numerous ‘exotic’ cultural oddities may lead one to believe that there are, indeed, many crucial contextual differences complicating the translation process, it seems sensible to endorse the attitude taken by Koller (1992:176). Koller points out that cultural differences should not be exaggerated, since – as is of course well known by any practising translator – expressions referring to culture-specific political, institutional, socio-economic, historical and geographical phenomena, which can only be understood in the particular cultural context in which they are embedded and which consequently lack a corresponding expression in the target culture, can nevertheless be translated by means of a variety of compensatory mechanisms (cf. de Waard and Nida, 1986, and see Jakobson, 1966). Elevating concrete, mundane and material differences between cultures such as differences in safety regulations or shopping routines to the rank of impenetrable cultural and translation barriers is both unnecessary and unproductive.

At the same time, despite the undeniable universality of the human condition, there are of course also subtle if crucial differences in cultural preferences, mentalities and values that need to be known to the translator when he or she embarks on a covert translation and sees the need to apply a cultural filter. Empirical research into contextually determined communicative preferences in the source and target communities can give more substance to the concept of a cultural filter than mere reliance on tacit native-speaker knowledge. In the case of the German and Anglophone linguistic and cultural communities, for example, evidence of differences in communicative norms is now available, i.e., the cultural filter has been substantiated through empirical contrastive-pragmatic analyses, as an outcome of which a set of Anglophone and German communicative preferences have been hypothesized. This type of research demonstrates how the notion of a cultural filter can be made more concrete and used as a device to explain (and justify) re-contextualization measures undertaken by the translator in covert translation.

A series of German–English contrastive pragmatic analyses were conducted over the past 30 years, in which native German and English texts and discourses using a variety of different subjects and methodologies² were compared.³ These yielded a series of individual results, which together provide converging evidence that points to a set of more general hypotheses about the nature of German–English contextually conditioned differences in text and discourse conventions. For example, in a variety of everyday situations and text types, German subjects tended to prefer expressing themselves in ways that are more direct, more explicit, more self-referenced and more content-oriented; they were also found to be less prone to resorting to the use of verbal routines than Anglophone speakers. This pattern of cross-cultural differences can be displayed along a number of dimensions such as directness versus indirectness, explicitness versus implicitness, orientation towards content versus orientation towards persons. These dimensions are to be understood as continua rather than clear-cut dichotomies, i.e., they reflect tendencies rather than categorical distinctions. In German discourse and texts, then, a

² These included open dyadic role-plays, retrospective interviews, discourse completion tests, meta-pragmatic assessment tests, authentic interactions between German and English native speakers, comparative analyses of German and English original texts, translations and comparable texts, field notes, interviews, diary studies, and the examination of relevant background documents.

³ For a summary of these studies, see Blum-Kulka et al. (1989), House (1996, 2003a) and the literature quoted therein.

transactional style focussing on the content of a message is frequently preferred, whereas in Anglophone discourse, speakers tend to prefer an interactional, addressee-focused manner of expression. In terms of the two Hallidayan functions of language, the ideational and the interpersonal, German texts and discourse often lean towards the ideational function, whereas Anglophone expressions tend to emphasize the interpersonal function.

By hypothesizing dimensions of cross-cultural difference in contextually derived text and discourse conventions, which add substance to the notion of a cultural filter, it is also implicitly suggested that language use is linked to its socio-cultural context, and that linguistic-textual differences in the realization of discourse can be taken to reflect deeper differences in cultural preference patterns. The hypothesized dimensions of context-based German-English differences are supported by similar results from other research (see in particular [Clyne, 1994](#)). The following examples of German-English translations illustrate the operation of these dimensions in the process of cultural filtering.

The first example comes from a corpus of German signs placed in different domains of public life ([House, 1996](#)). In many cases, these signs are accompanied by translations which, more often than not, reveal German-English differences of communicative preference, and thus the operation of a German-English cultural filter:

Example 1

Sign at Frankfurt Airport on display at a building site (original German):

Damit die Zukunft schneller kommt!

[Such that the future comes more quickly!]

vs. accompanying English translation:

We apologize for any inconvenience work on our building site is causing you!

The difference in perspective, i.e., a focus on content in German and an interpersonal focus in the English translation, is clearly noticeable here.

The following example is taken from [Luchtenberg \(1994\)](#), who has contrasted American and German software manuals. Compare:

Example 2

Software manual (original English)

WordPerfect is backed by a customer support system designed to offer you fast, courteous service. If you've exhausted all other Help avenues and need a friendly voice to help you with your problem, follow these steps. . . .

vs.

WordPerfect hat ein Support-Zentrum eingerichtet, dessen Mitarbeiter Ihnen bei Problemen kompetente Unterstützung anbieten. Wenn Sie trotz der in Word Perfect zur Verfügung stehenden Hilfsquellen ein Problem nicht lösen konnten, wenden Sie sich an unser Support-Zentrum.

[WordPerfect has established a Support Centre, whose employees offer you competent support with problems. If, despite the support available to you in WordPerfect, you were not able to solve a problem, turn to our support centre.]

The next example is taken from an instruction for using ovenware. A preference for greater explicitness in the German original compared to the English translation is clearly noticeable here:

Example 3

Instruction leaflet, oven ware (original German)

Kerafour ist in unabhängigen Prüfungsinstituten auf Ofenfestigkeit und Mikrowellenbeständigkeit getestet worden. Damit Sie lange Freude an ihm haben, geben wir Ihnen einige kurze Gebrauchshinweise:

-1. Stellen Sie nie ein leeres, kaltes Gefäß in den erhitzten Ofen (als leer gilt auch ein nur innen mit Fett bestrichenes Gefäß) . . .

[Kerafour has been tested for ovenproofness in independent testing institutes. So that you can enjoy it for a long time, we give you some brief instructions for use: 1. Never put an empty cold vessel into the heated oven (“empty” also refers to a vessel which is only rubbed with fat)]

vs.

Kerafour oven-to-table pieces have been tested by independent research institutes and are considered ovenproof and micro-wave resistant. Here are a few simple rules for using Kerafour.

-1. Never put a cold and empty piece into the heated oven. . .

In the second sentence, the German original gives an explicit reason for this instruction: “Damit Sie lange Freude an ihm haben”, which is left out in the English translation. And under 1., the German original – unlike the translation – explicitly defines the conditions under which the Kerafour pieces are to be considered ‘empty’.⁴ While one might of course assume that the German text producer was specifically instructed to avoid potentially costly consequences of a customer’s misinterpretation of ‘empty’, the interesting fact remains that the entire explicate bracket is left out in the English translation.

The analyses of German and English texts presented in House (1981, 1997) contain many more examples of cultural filtering in covert translation, all of which attest to translators’ attempts to take account of different cultural conventions in his or her task of re-contextualizing the source text.

2.4. Translations and versions

Over and above making a distinction between covert and overt translation in re-contextualizing processes, it is necessary to make another distinction in translation theory, namely a distinction between translations and versions. This distinction links up with the notion of equivalence and with the different types of equivalence that can be achieved in the act of re-contextualization.

Within the theory of re-contextualization outlined here, *an overt version* is produced whenever a special function is overtly added in the process of re-contextualization. Two different cases of overt version production come to mind. The first is when a translation is produced which is to reach a particular audience in a particular context. Examples are special editions for a youthful audience with the resultant omissions, additions, simplifications or different accentuations of certain features of the source text, or when specialist works (newly) designed for the lay public are drastically popularized. The second is when the translation is given an added special purpose. Examples include resumes and abstracts, where it is the express purpose of the version producer to pass on only the most essential fact or gist of the original.

⁴ One is reminded of Whorf’s (1939/1956:135) famous example of a fire hazard because of people’s habitually erroneous idea about a gasoline drum being ‘empty’, when in reality it contained explosive vapor!

A *covert version*, on the other hand, results whenever the translator – in order to preserve the function of the source text – applies a cultural filter in such a way as to manipulate the text according to her own ideological preferences and (covertly) produces a significantly different text, without the reader being alerted to the translator's deliberate interventions.

Returning to the three basic criteria for the validity of a re-contextualization theory of translation listed at the beginning of section 2, I would want to claim that because of (1) the provision of an elaborate categorial and metalinguistic apparatus for comparative contextualized analyses of texts, (2) the provision of the theoretical notion of the (context-derived) overt–covert cline, on which a translation is to be placed according to the type of text-to-context match sought, and (3) the provision of explicit means for distinguishing a translation from other types of multilingual textual operations, all three criteria are met in the proposed re-contextualization theory of translation.

3. Translation as *re-contextualization* under the influence of English as a global *lingua franca*

In the course of today's relentlessly increasing processes of globalization and internationalization in many aspects of contemporary life, there is also a rising demand for texts which are simultaneously meant for recipients in many different linguistic and cultural contexts. These texts are either translated covertly or produced immediately as 'comparable texts' in different languages. In the past, translators and text producers tended to routinely apply a cultural filter in such cases. However, due to the worldwide political, economic, scientific and cultural dominance of the English language – especially in its function as *lingua franca* – a tendency towards 'cultural universalism' or 'cultural neutralism', which is really a drift towards Anglo-American norms, has been set into motion. In the decades to come, the conflict between cultural universalism propelled by the need for fast and global dissemination of information on the one hand and culture specificity catering to local, particular needs on the other will become more marked. It is therefore plausible to hypothesize that much less cultural filtering in re-contextualization processes will occur in the future, with many more 'culturally universal', 'contextually homogenized' translation texts being routinely created as carriers of (hidden) Anglophone and West-European/North-Atlantic linguistic–cultural norms.⁵

While the influence of the English language in the area of lexis has long been acknowledged and bemoaned by many, Anglophone influence at the levels of pragmatics and discourse has hardly been recognized, let alone adequately researched. The effect of the shift in translation and multilingual text production towards neutral contexts in influential genres in many languages and cultures is therefore an important research area for the future. What is needed in this area is corpus-based research into hitherto unidentified problems. One first step in this direction has been made in a project currently funded by the German Research Foundation (DFG) into the influence of English as a global *lingua franca* on German, French and Spanish translation and comparable texts (cf. Baumgarten et al., 2004; Baumgarten and Probst, 2004; Bührig and House, 2004; House, 2003b, 2004). In this project, quantitative and qualitative diachronic analyses are conducted on the basis of multilingual primary and validation corpora of 550 texts (800,000 words) from popular science and economic genres as well as interviews and background material.

⁵ A well-known example is Enid Blyton's children's books, which owe much of their success and popularity to their bland, neutral context and universalism.

The analyses have shown that German communicative preferences – unlike French and Spanish ones – have indeed undergone a process of change under the influence of English over the past 25 years. Particularly vulnerable to English influence are certain functional categories such as personal deixis, co-ordinate conjunctions and modal particles, which function as a sort of trigger for contextually induced changes in text/discourse norms in both translations and comparable texts. To illustrate this trend, I will give two brief examples from the popular science corpus. In the first example (Example 4), it is the subject position in the German translation which points to English influence. Whereas a non-animate noun as agent in the subject position is routinely possible in English, it is marked in German in this genre:

Example 4

Michael Rose: “Can Human Aging be Postponed?” *Scientific American*, December 1999 (Original English)

Anti-ageing therapies of the future will undoubtedly have to counter many destructive biochemical processes at once.

Michael Rose: “Läßt sich das Altern aufhalten?” *Spektrum der Wissenschaft*, März 2000. (German Translation)

Wirksame Therapien müssen allerdings *den Kampf* gegen viele zerstörerische biochemische Prozesse gleichzeitig *aufnehmen*.

[Effective therapies must however take up the fight against many destructive biochemical processes simultaneously.]

The German translation in (4) shows that the Anglophone convention of personalizing inanimate, abstract entities is adopted, adding a persuasive force to the text and eliciting a potentially more emotive–affective response from addressees. In German, the passive would be a less marked construction: “Durch Anti-Altern Therapien der Zukunft muss vielen zerstörerischen biochemischen Prozessen zweifellos gleichzeitig entgegengewirkt werden” (‘Through anti-ageing therapies of the future many destructive biochemical processes will undoubtedly be countered at once’).

In Example 5, the sentence-initial use of the coordinate conjunction *und* is marked in German written text in this genre, and thus also points to the influence of English communicative conventions:

Example 5

Ian Tattersall: “Once we were not alone”, *Scientific American*, January 2000 (Original English)

As far as can be told, these two hominids behaved in similar ways despite anatomical differences. *And* as long as they did so, they somehow contrived to share the Levantine environment.

Ian Tattersall: “Wir waren nicht die einzigen”, *Spektrum der Wissenschaft*, März 2000 (German Translation)

Soweit wir dies beurteilen können, verhielten sich beide Menschenarten also trotz aller anatomischen Verschiedenheit offenbar gleich. *Und* solange beide dabei blieben, gelang es ihnen auch, diesen Lebensraum im Nahen Osten miteinander zu teilen.

[As far as we can judge this, both hominids behaved in a similar way despite all their anatomical differences. And as long as both stayed that way, they also succeeded in sharing the environment in the Near East.]

While initial *und* is used frequently in German in oral, particularly narrative discourse, it is marked in German written language, and in this genre. The use of sentence-initial *und* in (5) is an indication of a recent tendency towards colloquialization and oralization in the German popular science genre (but it is also noticeable in the genre of business communication; see Böttger, 2004). Such a tendency has long characterized this genre in the Anglophone context, but is new in the German tradition, where a more ‘scientific’, more ‘serious’ norm was traditionally followed (House, 1977:98ff), such that in popular science translations from English, a cultural filter was routinely employed so as to enable German addressees to be informed in their conventional, more detached manner, and not in the lightly entertaining tone used in the Anglophone originals. All this is now changing, and cultural filtering is no longer the rule.

The results of on-going analyses in the project described above show that re-contextualization processes both in English–German translations and in comparable texts are being transformed under the impact of global English. However, much more large-scale corpus-based research with different genres, language pairs and translation directions is clearly needed to document this development.

4. Conclusion

Recent conceptions of context have broken away from viewing context as a set of pre-fixed variables statically surrounding stretches of language. Context and text are now increasingly viewed as more dynamically related, and the relationship between linguistic and non-linguistic dimensions of communicative events are considered to be reflexive. Linguistic products and the interpretive work they generate in acts of communication and the enacting of discourse are regarded as shaping context as much as context shapes them. I have argued that this view – propagated in all approaches which focus on discourse-cum-negotiation – is not relevant for translation, because translation operates on written text and can only construct context and enact discourse *ex post facto*, never on-line. Functional approaches to language, functional pragmatics and Hallidayan systemic functional linguistics were given preference over philosophical, psychological, pragmatic, sociolinguistic and conversation analytic approaches because their notion of context was found to be more suitable for written text and thus for a theory of translation as re-contextualization. Re-contextualization was defined as taking a text out of its original frame and context and placing it within a new set of relationships and culturally conditioned expectations.

The distinction between overt and covert translation was shown to reflect very different ways of solving this task of re-contextualization: in overt translation the original’s context is reactivated alongside the target context, such that two different discourse worlds are juxtaposed in the medium of the target language; covert translation concentrates exclusively on the target context, employing a cultural filter to take account of the new addressees’ context-derived communicative norms. Covert translation is thus more directly affected by contextual and cultural differences. If language itself is seen as a context that influences thought and behaviour, the possibility of translation is theoretically denied. However, any strong hypothesis of linguistic relativity can be replaced in translation theory by a notion of linguistic–cultural relativity, thus allowing for translation as an act of re-contextualization including, in some instances, cultural filtering. Re-contextualization and cultural filtering are, however, today in danger of being undermined by the dominance of global English and the concomitant omnipresence of Anglophone communicative conventions. This development should, at the very least, be made

transparent through appropriate large-scale research, such that the consequences of the imposed separation of texts from their contexts can be exposed.

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